

La Peau de Changrin

(who is afraid of the shrinking skin....!)

Sanjeev Khandekar

2005

www.vaishaliandsanjeev.com

Body, Interrupted

Abhay Sardesai

1.

For Sanjeev Khandekar, being in the middle of a compromise-ridden social life equals being in the throes of a disease. The corporeal body, always within quotation marks, is therefore for him, a metaphorical presence that stands for larger corporate/socio-political/global institutional bodies. The sites of infection that he summons up are as much within as without: you have terror-inspiring insects crawling over and ripping into the fibreglass frame of a figure on display, there are protein-maps of dying cells tattooed on a disembodied leg, and finally, you have an entire gallery transformed into a body-shop.

2.

As you enter the Museum Gallery, you are greeted not by extended hands but by four torso-less legs, each wrapped by either a stock index ticker, a print-out of a seismograph, a circuit diagram of an IPU, and as mentioned earlier, by protein-maps of dying cells. The fibre-glass legs are part of a quasi-theatrical evocation of the legend of Vamana (from the *Dasha-avataara*), where a young Brahmin partakes of the generosity of the Asura king, Bali, who grants him three wishes. The Brahmin, who is none other than Vishnu himself, takes two strides and covers the earth and the heaven, and in the third stride, stomps over King Bali, who offers himself as he is honour-bound to fulfil the promise he has made. While joining issue with the Dalit critiques of Brahminism, Khandekar's ensemble draws attention to the very processes that rationalize and hagiographise predatory heroism.

As we move in, we enter a gallery within the gallery: under a black sky, hang dismembered fibreglass body-parts, lit from within. You can shop here for the spleen, haggle over a food-pipe, and finger the large intestines and the rectum. The intention is not as much to create a perverse spectacle as it is to draw our attention to the various contradictory politico-social force-fields that the body finds itself moored in. Michel Foucault draws our attention to the inter-relationship between the body as a material entity and the body as represented in a variety of discursive fields. The body, he says, is anchored in/to contexts where power relations "invest it mark it, train it, and torture it, for it to carry out tasks, to perform ceremonies, to emit signs." Violence inflicted on the body is an attempt at destroying its subjectivity, erasing its voice, and controlling its agency. It is the *reducibility* of the body that the installation draws our attention to: where the organs have become objects, and the will to orchestrate them is an absent presence. The discoloured nerve-networks, the branching tendons, the pressure-marks that make these objects come alive, as it were, also lead us to dwell on their histories of use and abuse: in fact, on the very textures of life. The different tiles that are laid out on the floor and the flayed-body, capillary-network wall-paper talk of the processual transformation of a human being from flesh-and-blood wholeness to bone-and-marrow skeletalness. The interstitial ambiguities between pain and pleasure, the ascendancy of pain over pleasure, the grotesqueness of a dissected viscera, and of the devouring gaze, lead

us to cogitate about the various dynamiques that aid the erasure of self-hood in a man, and even more importantly, in a woman. In spite of the complex porosities, the manipulable body displaces the sentient body: the body, as a whole, therefore becomes a site for a border-dispute, where transactions about interiority and exteriority, about fixity and dynamism, about ownership, are enacted.

3.

Khandekar's exhibition at the Museum Gallery is titled *All That I Wanna Do*: the bite of the irony of the Americanism can be appreciated with greater force if one goes through Khandekar's second book of poems in Marathi of the same name. The poems contain numbing Meditations on the altered fate of the post-modern man as the heir to a conspiracy not only of circumstance but also of religion, technology and politics. In fact, the rapacious acquisitiveness of the...

...first world, the progressively thicker economic segmentation of worlds produced by lop-sided globalisation, the duplicity of wars against terror, have been events/issues that have obsessed, even haunted and marked Khandekar.

The body (strategically gendered in some cases and non-gendered in others) is a kind of a landscape for Khandekar, which allows for various kinds of entries, and exits. Has the whole body become less than the sum of its parts, is the troubled question he seems to ask. As we wind through the organ-bazaar, we come face to face with a complexly absurd installation: called *Shri Sugarcane Juice Centre/Gokul Milk Centre*.

It consists of several devices and half-devices, massed cheek by jowl, locked one into the other, which come together to assemble a kind of a parodied uber-machine. The relentless excessivity you find in the environment of a market, both at the level of the idea and the experience, is mimicked in this act of orchestrating together items that belong to diverse transactional worlds. The driller, the shredder, the sugarcane-crusher lie ensconced next to transistor-circuits, TV tubes, mini-piano keyboards, old radio-innards; jewellery, lipsticks, powder-packs rub shoulders with watches, pulleys, and *bindu*-inspired *yantras*. Cables stretch from one level to another, car-hoses trip over one another, wires go through the motions of cross-connecting or remaining open-ended. This hysterical piece self-consciously assumes preposterous proportions: the artist, with his privileged judiciousness, has been replaced, we feel, by the fringe-collector, the madman, the cracked inventor.

How does our desire to consume lead us to occupy roles that transform us into tragi-comic hoarders? The consumer, we realize, is a social archetype of the post-modern world: he is caught between the will to possess objects, both abstract and concrete, and the ambition to aspire for greater gloss, brighter flash. The more he consumes, the more his appetite grows, and the less he remains aware of the erasure of agency. Khandekar's installation hopes to engage with the claustrophobic and asphyxiating socio-spatialities we inhabit: our dystopic cityscapes are both monumental and dangerously casual in the ways in which they evolve. In the process of becoming a slapdash archive of urban detritus, the installation summons up a sinister techno-carnality: notice the array of rubber nipples attached to cut plastic bottles peeking out of holes at the back of the installation. Notice also the semen-like dried resin in

the front. Though viewed classically as an extension of the body, technology, thanks to the various intimidating uses it has been put to, has been considered by several amongst us as possessing sinister possibilities that are anti-civilisational. Some of the points that the French philosopher Jean Baudrillard raises in the course of an essay on J.G. Ballard's novel, *Crash*, help illuminate the relationship between the body and the machine:

"The technological is never grasped except by (auto) accident; in other words, by the violence done to itself and the violence done to the body. It is all identical: all shocks, all collisions, all impacts. The metallurgy of accidents is inscribed in a semiurgy of the body not in anatomy or physiology, but in a semiurgy of contusions, scars, mutilations, and wounds which are like new sexual organs opened in the body... Gone are the "erogenous zones": everything becomes a hole for reflex discharges... Bodies and technology each diffract through the other their own frantic symbols."³

Interestingly, the provocative anthropomorphization of technology points with renewed vigour at the complementary mechanization of the human body. In Khandekar's installation, it is in fact the disappearance of the body as an index of human presence that strikes us, surrounded as we are in the gallery, by parts of the alimentary canal, hung like in an abattoir.

4.

The body however makes an appearance at Pundole Art Gallery, a five-minute walk from the Museum gallery. The second part of the show continues here (or the first part, if you are coming from the V.T. side of the city). A life-size fiberglass figure of the artist in a classic sitting position is reflected by a mirror that is fixed to the ceiling. As you enter the gallery within the gallery, you wonder whether the exhibit here marks the return of the body made whole, the return of health, as it were. It is the *yantra*-tile on the floor that grabs your attention: you realize how several kinds of plastic/fibre insects have occupied places within it to form a mosaic that upsets its sacred spatial demands. And even as you feel the minatory presence of these insects, produced in a range of toxic hues, stationed in holes punched in the gallery walls, you are struck by the slyness with which infection spreads, the deceptive modes by which diseases proliferate. Khandekar's figure (which sits on a car-engine) has its back chewed open, its vertebrae exposed, has these monstrous specimens clambering onto the black hollow that has opened out. The body has been emptied of organs; what we see is just a hollow frame.

The surveillance of the body by creatures with carnivorous eyes, and the ironic impossibility of any kind of self-referentiality despite the presence of a reflection that looks down from the ceiling, contributes to the creation of a real and symbolic environment, where the visible human presence itself is seen being leaked away, where exteriorities of diverse kinds are seen being pathetically stripped off, where, in short, death itself is transformed into a macabre performance. The menace of bio-technological mutation is more than just a suggestion here: even the hollow carapace of the human body becomes an object of cruel consumption.

5.

Do we go away from Khandekar's works then feeling hopelessly traumatized by a turn-of-the-century *Weltschmerz*? Michel Foucault, in his later works, came to observe that within the very contexts of power relations, there exist the possibilities of resistance. In a different key, then, the very act of critically depicting and detailing a catastrophic world could well provide us with clues to shore up our defences, to develop strategic life-affirming technologies of the self.

Footnotes:

1. Jotirao Phule, for instance, found in the *Vamana* story, a representation of the treacherous victory of Brahminical factions over groups of indigenous peoples. In Jotirao's and Dhondiba's *Dialogue in Slavery* (Gulamgiri, 1873), there is an extended discussion of the ten avatars of Vishnu: we find Jotirao here, vigorously analyzing, exposing, and critiquing the ideological biases underpinning the construction of religious mythologies. (Ref: *Selected Writings of Jotirao Phule*. Edited by G.P. Deshpande. Translated by Maya Pandit. LeftWord Books. 2002.)
2. *The Foucault Reader: An Introduction to Foucault's Thought*. Ed. Paul Rabinow. Penguin, London. 1991.
3. Jean Baudrillard's essay, *Ballard's Crash*, looks at issues raised by the cult-novel, which according to Ballard himself, was the "first pornographic novel based on technology". Baudrillard's essay was first published in 1976. It was reproduced in translation in *Science Fiction Studies: Special issue on Science Fiction and Postmodernism* (#55, November 1991.)

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'Journey through the Corporate Black Hole'

Kumar Ketkar

Sanjeev Khandekar has gone berserk.
When an artist goes berserk, he deconstructs everything.
He does not like the world handed down to him by God.
The artist wants to rip it apart and reconstruct it.
He distrusts God.
He feels God has played dice with him. Sanjeev hates anybody being dicey with him.
That perhaps is the motive behind the installation that he has raised.
He wants to redefine the human body, so that he can search for a soul within it.
He is not even sure whether there is a soul anywhere. In the body or anywhere else.
If indeed there is a soul, it must enter the installation.
Or else it must remain condemned to non-existence.
It must have been an exercise in frustration because his idea perhaps was to create an art-piece.
But ended up in creating a parallel prototype universe instead.
Sanjeev's problems did not end there.
He wanted, it seems, to be in three roles. All at the same time.
He wanted to be the Creator, replacing God, an artist and a critic of his own work.
That is why the viewer too must simultaneously travel in all the three streams of
Consciousness.
Without which he cannot connect himself with the installation.
We have all seen an automobile ripped open in a garage.
Or an aeroplane in hanger, getting repaired.
Or a surgeon who has opened the body for a major operation.
There are a few mechanics around the car, with spanners and screwdrivers and a lamp.
All of them in full concentration and without any communication with each other.
As if they are dissecting a body, lifeless and soulless.
They are searching for a humming sound, buzzing noise, for a sudden jerk.
Only that will prove that the car has life.
There are over a dozen mechanics and engineers standing atop the plane.
It is difficult to understand how they locate the circuits and wires in the Complicated maze.
It is like an Amazon jungle, in which a few adventurers have entered with a rough map.
They are working at different ends of the plane and yet appear to be working in perfect tandem.

Sanjeev has installed that bizarre late night dream.
Now it is more a challenge to the critic than the artist.

The challenge is at once intellectual and spiritual. Ideological and political.
Because the last two decades have confused everybody.
The post-modernists have given the Great Confusion an attractive wardrobe.
The intellectuals look at the wardrobe and try to imagine the human body in it.
They create a mannequin and treat it like a human.
Like a customer who walked with his wife into a magnificent shopping mall;
And left the wife on some counter and began to walk with the mannequin.
Indeed, he lived happily thereafter with the mannequin. The mannequin never argued back.
Never cried. Never demanded anything. Had no grievances.
The relationship was stable.
But this relatively stable psycho-spiritual relationship was a challenge for the artist.
His intellectual complacency was shattered. And the post-modernist philosopher was of no help. For almost four decades after the second world war, the artist had masqueraded as a Visionary.
He was above ideology, beyond political skulduggery, even beyond the shackles of reality.
The artist distinguished himself by penetrating into the collective unconscious.
He was not a communist, because communism constrained his creativity and freedom.
He was not a defender of capitalism either.
Because he believed art was beyond the reach of market forces.
He could not have been a fascist, or a fundamentalist. Art was his religion.
The artists envied technology. Technology was emerging as a parallel religion to art.
Ever since the Renaissance, the artists have been competing with the technocrats and scientists.
Both claim to be in search of Truth. Both want to rise beyond ideology.
Both want to construct and re-construct Reality.
Both crave for vision. Both want to claim and command consciousness.
Both want to go from here to Eternity.
Sanjeev's installation has been constructed out of that angst.

It is an effort to create a world view, a parallel perspective, a concept.
Like the Renaissance artist, Sanjeev is immensely enamoured and infatuated with machines.
Be it a sugarcane juice crusher or a personal computer.
The plethora of screws and spares in the installation are manifestation of that obsession.
Does a machine have a soul? Indeed do all humans have a soul?
Most humans, Sanjeev seems to suggest, are no different than machines.
Soulless robots. Work. Earn. Spend. Have sex. Perform. Get on to the next Act. Work...Earn...
True, machines don't have sex. But don't humans have sex like machines?
Simulated Passion. Calculated Performance. Anticipated Result. As per an MBA pert chart.
Even love is corporate now and sex is like marketing. Measured in terms of success and failure.

This corporatisation of all psychological as well as physiological world is reflected in the installation.
Kidneys can be marketed. Now even sperms. Soon there would be a trade-fair of sperms.
Sperms of different ethnicities, races, colours. Channels will advertise different brands.

The surgeon carrying out the operation too is quiet. He is surrounded by nurses, machines.
There is a huge, bright light over the body, illuminating the labyrinthine intestines.
And blood...blood all over. On handgloves, on scissors and knives. On aprons. On bed.
But that sight does not create revulsion in the minds of doctors and nurses.
The chief surgeon, even though the mask, looks like the Buddha.
The surgeon has seen beyond the body and blood.

He has seen the soul. The body and the blood is a myth.
The soul is the reality.
In fact, the car mechanics, the aeroplane engineers and the surgeon all have seen the soul.
They have seen, but cannot prove they have.
But they don't care, whether they can prove or not.
They have achieved Nirvana and that's it.
So has Sanjeev achieved Nirvana.
But strangely, he is so skeptical, that even that Nirvana sounds to him as virtual.
The computers in the installation obfuscate the thin line that divides the real from the virtual.
The reality confronts the viewer in the form of Vagina.
It is not a pleasure zone. It is not even a birthplace. It is a struggle to see beyond the Dark cave.
It is an obsession. It is fear of the unknown. It is a proof of material reality of passion.
Of angst. Of a riddle. Of God's cunning game of dice.
Sex is God's dice.
There was no necessity for God to confuse men and women with those organs.
He could have opted for something else, something less confusing, less intriguing.
But he wanted to trick the men and women he created.
He wanted to see them getting perplexed, getting lost, getting frustrated, getting wild.
God was enjoying the game woven around the mystery of the vaginal cave.
And the penis in search of identity.
Sanjeev, the artist, has realised that the soul has been trapped by God.
So Sanjeev wants to provide an escape route for the soul and let it run away from The trap.
Realising that the soul cannot escape, the artist wants to challenge the Creator.
He installs the trapped and devastated soul as a monument of art.
As if he is cautioning all of us not to get trapped by God with his cunning dice.
But the caution, instead of making us aware, actually infatuates us with the riddle.
The riddle is old. Who Am I?
Get rid of those intestines. Those testicles. That lever, kidney, and even the torso.
Stop the machine and let the heart beats stop.
Let the blood dry and electronic machines display a horizontal line.
Let there be Quietness. Like in the mountains.
Total tranquility.
May be there is that Soul, which too has managed to run away from God.
The Great Escape of the Soul from God has liberated the artist.
From the rules of the game, from the watchful eye of umpires, from the toss, from uncertainties.
Both the artist and the soul are running away and suddenly find themselves in an encounter.
The encounter is without words. Only images. Like in a bizarre late night dream.

Sanjeev perhaps wants to ridicule this virtual world of artificiality of corporate brands.
In which packaging is more important than product.
Cosmetics more important than the face.
Mirror image more real than the REAL.
That is why we are dazzled into vast mirrors. Sanjeev's huge mirrors are to confuse us.
The mirrors are NOT imaging the reality.
They reflect the installed realities.
So the choice is between the installed reality or mirror image of it.
In search of the REAL reality, Sanjeev has apparently lost his way. And is enjoying it.
The Amazon jungle, the labyrinthine intestinal network, the automobile machine, the aeroplane.
The organs hanging all over. As if they have independent existence.
As if they don't need body.
Nor do they need soul or even life force. The organs are lit from within.
What we see is not real. It is a make-believe.
What we experience is not love and passion. It is a simulation of both.
Sanjeev seems to suggest that it is not necessary to have sex for pleasure or for reproduction.
Rather for corporate success. Your corporate confidence level will be measured in bed.
There would be a meter attached to every bed and the results would be processed.
The data would be computerised and handed over to the Human Resource Director.
Promotion and increment will be determined according to the Performance level.
Because the HRD would prove it to the directors that only those who perform in bed—
Would be able to perform in the intensely competitive market situation.
This measurement of Machoness is reflected in the fresco-like display of vagina.
A Black Hole from where light cannot emanate but energy can.

Sanjeev's installation could be interpreted as a protest against the bourgeois unreality.
But like all artists he also recognises the REALITY of the market.
After all, like all the artists, he too is in the market.
Though they do not believe in the market forces, they desperately solicit the market.
Though artists appear to believe in simplicity, they like to indulge in some luxuries.
Artists encourage libertarianism, even of the Ayan Randish kind.
Because that gives them freedom without responsibility.
Though the artist celebrates the triumph of Individualism, he is fearful of Individuality.
Because Individuality demands objectivity, originality, creativity, and sensitivity.

Artists don't like objectivity because they thrive on subjectivism.
They want the objective world to appreciate their subjective appreciation of reality!
This cacophony of contradictions and setback to conventional wisdom was a new challenge.
Intellectually and aesthetically. For the writers, thinkers, and for the artists.
They wanted to deconstruct what was already disintegrating.
They hated kitsch and cliches. But could not create an absolutely original idea.
It was indeed a monumental challenge. Marx appeared to have had exhausted all original ideas.
The very expression of "post-modern" betrayed the idea of originality.
It was not as if Marx did not "deconstruct". He indeed did it.
But that does not make him a post-modernist.
Marx wanted to construct an ideal world out of the bourgeois chaos.

Though he and Engels were not utopians, what they visualised was a post-modern Utopia.
The disintegration of the Soviet Union was the disintegration of that idea of utopia.
That was because the Soviet State itself had RDXed the utopia.
That is why hardly any artist, any writer, any playwright in Russia regretted the Great Fall.
But to their horror, they saw no new idea, system, concept, ideology emerging.
The artists may detest any ideological construct, but they want something out there.
Without that point of reference, they cannot position themselves.
Sanjeev's dilemma is even worse.
He is not anti-ideology. In that sense, he is not post-modernist.
He is not a Marxist, in a conventional sense.
And yet he is not an anti-communist or anti-Marxist in the American neo-con sense.
This is a difficult position to maintain, particularly for a writer or an artist.
Many in this politico-ideological vacuum either turned to vague spirituality.
Or to Right-wing political Hinduism in India.

They began to look for Vedic motifs, to ancient scriptures, to ritualistic symbols.
Even to the Swastika

Sanjeev has realised that the corporate takeover of the world is no less alarming.
If left unchallenged, the corporates would achieve what Hitler failed to do.
That is why, everybody must join a fight against the New Swastika.
The artists too have a role to play.
To alert the world, and if necessary to de-construct their vision.
To tell the customer that he has walked away with a mannequin.
Sanjeev's installation is not neutral.
He has waved a flag.
We have to decide whether to follow the flag or get gobbled up by the corporate Swastika.

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Title: 'Portrait of an artist riding an engine'
Medium: Fibre, acrylic, synthetic fur, steel and copper
Size: 64" x 27" x 42"
Year: 2005